

Diarrhea and vomiting

» Symptoms:

Watery, loose stools, that may be mucus stained and smelly, indicate diarrhea. Vomiting is when your baby brings up a sizeable quantity of milk (rather than a few teaspoons' worth). Causes include gastroenteritis, reflux, and allergy.

» What you should do:

Talk to your doctor. He or she may suggest replacing fluids your baby is losing to prevent dehydration by offering frequent feedings; giving oral rehydration solution in addition, or cooled, boiled water if your baby refuses the solution. Make sure to consult your doctor if your baby has had diarrhea six or more times, or has vomited three or more times, in the last 24 hours, has a rash, fever, signs of dehydration, or blood in his vomit or stool. For more advice about fluids, see Dehydration, left.

Reflux

» Symptoms:

Frequent regurgitation of milk and stomach acid. (Some spitting up is normal—the muscular valve that closes the stomach doesn't fully develop until 12–18 months.)

» What you should do:

Feed in smaller amounts more frequently, and burp often. Avoid overfeeding; for bottle-fed babies, try a nipple with a smaller hole. Hold your baby upright after feeding to ease reflux. See your doctor if your baby has frequent reflux with coughing, gagging, persistent crying, or poor weight gain.

Colds and flu

» Symptoms:

A runny nose, a cough, red eyes, and sometimes a raised temperature. Cold symptoms combined with a sudden fever of 100.4° F (38° C) or more may indicate a flu. Other signs of flu are lethargy, lack of appetite, vomiting, and diarrhea.

» What you should do:

Call your doctor who might recommend making sure your baby gets plenty of fluids (see Dehydration, left). If your baby has a stuffed nose and feeding is difficult, try raising the humidity levels to loosen his mucus: put a bowl of warm water in the room or sit in a steamy room. You can buy saline nasal drops to help thin the mucus from pharmacies. Your baby will also need to sleep more while he is recovering from a cold.

Ear infections

» Symptoms:

It can be hard to tell if a baby has an ear infection, but if he rubs or tugs on his ear, is irritable, isn't feeding normally, vomits, doesn't respond to quieter noises, and has a temperature a few days after the onset of a cold, he may have an ear infection. Pus may appear if the eardrum is damaged.

» What you should do:

Ear infections usually clear up in about three days without treatment. If your baby is under three months old and has a temperature of 100.4° F (38° C) or more, or is under six months old with a temperature of 102.2° F (39° C), consult your doctor. He or she may prescribe antibiotics if your baby is under three months old. A warm washcloth over the ear can be soothing. Repeated infections may be treated with tympanostomy tubes—tubes inserted in the ear to drain fluid.

Bronchiolitis

» Symptoms:

Symptoms are similar to a cold with a fever. They may worsen after a few days and include a dry, rasping cough, noisy or fast breathing, brief pauses between breaths, vomiting, feeding less, and having fewer wet diapers.

» What you should do:

Symptoms usually clear up in a couple of weeks. If your baby is under three months and has a temperature of 100.4° F (38° C) or more, or is under six months with a temperature of 102.2° F (39° C), consult your doctor. Keep your baby hydrated, and upright as much as possible to ease congestion. A humidifier, or bowl of warm water in a room keeps the air moist. Call your doctor (or an ambulance if you're very concerned) if your baby is having difficulty breathing, is breathing rapidly, isn't feeding well and hasn't had a wet diaper in the last 12 hours, or is unresponsive or is irritable.

Croup

» Symptoms:

Difficulty in breathing and a distinctive barking cough. Croup most commonly affects children between six months and three years old, but can occur in younger babies.

» What you should do:

Mild croup can be managed at home. Keep your baby hydrated, hold him upright to ease breathing, and comfort him, as crying worsens symptoms. Your doctor may prescribe an oral corticosteroid to reduce swelling in the throat.

Whooping cough (pertussis)

» Symptoms:

A dry, persistent cough with prolonged bouts of coughing, interspersed with gasps for air. There may be a runny nose, fever, and vomiting. Coughing may last for months.

» What you should do:

Get a vaccination against the virus between 28 and 38 weeks of pregnancy to protect your baby at birth, and have your baby vaccinated at two months old. If your baby has symptoms, consult your doctor immediately, who may give antibiotics. If he has trouble breathing, call an ambulance.

Meningitis

» Symptoms in babies:

Meningitis is a viral or bacterial infection of the membranes surrounding the brain and spinal cord. Symptoms include a bulging fontanelle; a fever with cold hands and feet (although young babies may have a normal or low temperature); sleepiness; rapid breathing; grunting; a high-pitched or moaning cry; shivering; stiffness and jerking or floppiness; irritability from muscle aches—perhaps not wanting to be picked up; diarrhea and vomiting; a stiff neck; dislike of bright lights; blotchy skin; and convulsions or seizures. A purple “pinprick” rash or purple bruises that don't disappear under a pressed glass, may indicate blood poisoning—a medical emergency. Symptoms can occur in any order.

» What you should do:

Don't wait for a rash to appear before getting help. If you suspect meningitis, call an ambulance immediately and say that you suspect meningitis.



The glass test A rash that doesn't disappear under a pressed glass indicates blood poisoning.